Five Bright Planets to Spot in November

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November is a great month for watching planets. You can see them in the evening, around midnight, or just before the sun rises.

In the evening, look for Saturn high in the southern sky. Around midnight, Mars and Jupiter rise in the **east-northeast**. Early in the month, Mars moves toward Jupiter, passes it on November 16, and then moves away.

Venus is the star of the early morning sky. On November 1, it rises 55 minutes before the sun. By the end of the month, it rises nearly three and a half hours before the sun and shines at its brightest.

Mercury joins the morning show in the middle of the month. It is farthest from the sun on November 20. Here is a trick: your fist, held out at **arm's length**, covers about 10 **degrees** of sky.

On November 7, a thin **crescent** moon, Venus, and the blue star Spica bunch together before sunrise.

Word Treasure

crescent -- A crescent is a thin, curved shape, like the moon looks when only a small part is lit.

degrees -- Degrees are units used to measure angles, including how much of the sky something covers.

east-northeast -- East-northeast is a direction halfway between east and northeast.

arm's length -- At arm's length means holding something as far away as your stretched-out arm can reach.

Background you need

Planets shine in the night sky and can be seen at different times: in the evening, around midnight, or just before the sun rises.

Where a planet appears changes through the month, so sky watchers check dates and directions to find each one.

Venus is especially bright in the early morning sky in November, and Mercury joins the morning show in the middle of the month.

Break it down

WHO: The five bright planets Saturn, Mars, Jupiter, Venus and Mercury, which sky watchers can spot.

WHAT: Five bright planets can be seen at different times during November.

WHERE: In the evening sky, around midnight, and in the early morning sky before sunrise.

WHY: The planets appear at different times and places in the sky through the month, and Venus shines at its brightest by the end of it.

Why it matters

Children can try this themselves, looking up at the right time to spot real planets in the sky.

Test what you remember

1. Which planet can you look for high in the southern sky in the evening?

- (A) Jupiter
- (B) Mars
- (C) Venus
- (D) Saturn

2. Which two planets rise in the east-northeast around midnight?

- (A) Mercury and Venus
- (B) Jupiter and Mercury
- (C) Saturn and Venus
- (D) Mars and Jupiter

3. On which date does Mars pass Jupiter?

- (A) November 16
- (B) November 7
- (C) November 20
- (D) November 1

4. Which planet is the star of the early morning sky?

- (A) Saturn
- (B) Venus
- (C) Mars
- (D) Mercury

5. When is Mercury farthest from the sun?

- (A) On November 1
- (B) At the end of the month
- (C) On November 20
- (D) Around midnight

6. What covers about 10 degrees of sky?

- (A) A crescent moon
- (B) The blue star Spica
- (C) Venus before sunrise
- (D) Your fist, held out at arm's length

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):